

How do you retain employees?

I am the Manager of Employee Experience at Crescent Parts & Equipment, and HVAC-R wholesale distributor headquartered in St. Louis. We have approximately 160 employees in 17 different locations throughout Missouri, Illinois, and Iowa. In the post-COVID era, I've been wanting to come up with new and innovative ways to retain our employees and make their experience at CPE a great one. I found myself thinking in class how I could use these techniques to approach this question, and I knew immediately it would be the topic for this report. For simplicity's sake, I shorten the wording in the question I'm asking, however, I do believe that employee retention starts with the hiring process, continues through to the employee's retirement/termination, and everything in between. During the rest of this report, I will be creating ideas for all facets of the employee experience.

Associating*: I used the brute think technique we learned in class to associate 20 words to a noun I was given through a random word generator. From there, I generated the following ideas: create a bring your kid to work day, invite new hire's spouse to orientation, celebrate a fun "National Day Holiday" each month, create an employee rec sport team, have an employee family event with live music, create an "Employee of the Year" program and have the award be a trip somewhere, and have employees switch branches for a week so they can experience a different city and see how that branch does business.

Observing: I got really lucky here, my cousin Christina graduated from Loyola University Chicago last weekend with her undergraduate degree in Anthropology! I recruited her to spend the day with me (coffee and lunch on me, of course!) and we spent some time in our Main Office and in a few of our Metro St. Louis branches observing our employees. At the end of the day, we compared observations (I shared mine first, and to my surprise, most of what Christina noticed, I noticed too!), and I came up with the following ideas:

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- Our Counter Sales employees sit on counter height stools while working, and they are constantly getting up and down to grab something just out of reach – to solve this, CPE could purchase rolling counter height office chairs, so that they can roll the short distances and not have to continually get on and off the stool.
- Counter employees also stand a lot (instead of sitting) and we both noticed them shifting their weight from one leg to the other – to solve this, we could purchase antifatigue mats (see Experimenting). We could also give employees a stipend to purchase good, supportive footwear.
- The Main Office is very noisy (it's an open office plan), and most employees have in/on headphones to drown out the background noise or tie up a conference room when on a phone call – the expensive way to solve this would be to completely renovate the office to create small individual offices for each employee. The more cost-effective way would be to invest in a white noise system that helps to drown out background noise. We could also give each employee a stipend to purchase headphones.

Questioning*: I used the reverse assumption technique in which I came up with a list of assumptions about working at Crescent and then reversed those assumptions. From there, I generated a bunch of ideas, including introducing a maternity/paternity leave program (we don't currently have one), becoming an ESOP, and purchasing a helicopter or jet to get to our non-Metro STL branches (obviously, some are much more feasible than others). I also used a prohibitive constraint (only hire/employ women) and came back to the maternity/paternity leave program, as well as adding a Mother's Room at our Main Office, fertility and postpartum benefits, and implementing a policy where new parents can bring their younger-than-school-aged kids to work with them.

Networking*: I reached out to three dormant ties and had some successful ideas. My first two calls were to former colleagues that I worked with at Mercy Home for Boys & Girls, a nonprofit in Chicago, Illinois, but my last call, to Shelly Lilley at American Metals, proved to be the most helpful. The ideas were mainly for new hires, and they included: a welcome call from the manager (or next level up manager) after the candidate accepts the offer; schedule welcome coffee/lunch with the candidate, their new manager and one other employee that they'll work with before start date; send a welcome text 48 hours before the candidate start telling them how excited you are; give more company swag on the day

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they start; have manager meet the new hire at the door every day their first week; and have the new hire start and end every day the first week with the new hire's manager.

Teaming: I scheduled a meeting for 6 employees and myself – all of them were from different areas of our business: purchasing, accounting, marketing, operations, service and support, and IT. I started the meeting explaining my assignment, the question that I'm trying to answer, and the Brute Think Technique. I then assigned everyone a random noun and had them complete the Brute Think exercise. When everyone was finished, I shared my Brute Think exercise (explained in detail at the end of this assignment) and laid the brainstorming ground rules (don't criticize, encourage all ideas, more is better, build on others' ideas). Once I felt they had a good grasp of the rules, I had each employee share their ideas. We came up with tons of ideas, and ultimately thought the following were most feasible: create a hardship fund for employees to support them when they have hardships; give employees more PTO; create a program to recognize employees when they demonstrate our Mission, Vision and Values, call it Challenge Coins and give out only when employees go above and beyond; create a suggestion program for employees to submit ideas on how to improve our business; and create a mentorship program for new employees and match them with current employees.

Experimenting*: There was a lot of energy around the ideas generated during our Teaming session, and I recruited some of my colleagues to help me in the experimenting process. Here's a few of the experiments I led: creating a Hardship Fund through the United Way, our Challenge Coin program which recognized employees that represent our values by going above and beyond, purchasing antifatigue mats, and surveying employees about our PTO policies.

Pitching: Crescent's leadership team meets bi-weekly, which allowed for the perfect opportunity to pitch some of my ideas. The meeting is two hours long, and our agenda consists of some static items (like company financials and team updates) and others add items in as things come up – I was able to pitch two ideas to the team so far (on two separate occasions), and plan to continue pitching bi-weekly until I run out of ideas.

Challenge Coins: I enlisted the help of the employee who came up with the idea, Kyle, and together we presented the idea to the leadership group. We brought our prototype, but also had photos of what the real coin would look like (see end of report for photos). We first told the group that we wanted a way to

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recognize employees that go above and beyond. We then told the story of one employee, Eric, who was waiting on a customer in Davenport, Iowa. Eric realized that the part the customer needed was in Burlington, Iowa, about an hour and a half away. It was 4pm on a Friday, and our branches were about to close. Eric told the customer to go back to the job site, and he'd have the part there as soon as possible. He then called the Branch Manager in Burlington, and asked if he'd either stay open, or meet him at our branch in Burlington at 6pm. Eric drove to Burlington, picked up the part, and then drove to the customer's job site, about an hour north of Davenport to deliver the part. No one asked him to do this, and we likely have a lifelong customer now because of it. After finishing the story, we asked the group for ideas on what they think we could do to recognize Eric – we wrote them down on the power point for everyone to see, and then brought up the image of the Challenge Coin and passed around our prototype. The whole presentation took about 10 minutes, and the leadership group embraced the idea wholeheartedly. I've already placed the order for the actual, metal coins!

Hardship Fund: Over the past few years, we've had two employees whose teenage children were in horrific vehicle accidents – luckily both kids are alive and doing well today, but both accidents resulted in long hospital stays and months of rehab after. I started my presentation out by reminding the group of these two stories (I had current photos of both kids in the power point) and explained to them that I wished we had a more formal way to support these families. Prior to the meeting, I connected with United Way, and had a concrete policy for our leadership team to react to – there's several hardships that are outlined in the policy, and if an employee experiences one of those, they can apply to get funds from the Crescent Hardship Fund, which is managed by United Way. The whole group loved the idea, and even added onto it by suggesting we invite employees to get involved by donating to the fund as well. We are launching the Hardship Fund to employees in our monthly all company meeting at the end of June.

Next Steps: I have a sample paternity leave policy drafted to present to the group next week and am working on my emotional story to tell. Additionally, I have a meeting scheduled with our HR team to present the new onboarding ideas that came from my networking call with Shelly. Both HR team members are new within the last year, so I plan to play on their first day emotions and ask them to remember how they felt.

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Full notes on Associating – Brute Think Technique:

My starting word was PATCH → Layla → family → kids → fun → colorful → rainbow → inclusive → equality → openness → hugs → friends → Megan → high school → Nerinx Hall → reunion → concert → live music → outdoors → travel → joyful. From there, I generated the following ideas:

- Kids—bring your kid to work day; send employees’ kids a gift during holiday season; fund a scholarship for employee’s kids who are going to college
- Family—bring your family to work day; invite new employee’s spouse to New Hire Orientation
- Fun—come up with a theme each month and do something to have fun around it (i.e. on National Hot Dog Day send hot dogs to all the locations/employees); create a team of CPE employees for a rec league sport (softball, volleyball, kickball, etc.); set up an Employee Appreciation Day where all employees do team building/fun activities (escape rooms, laser tag, paint ball, shooting range, team sports, etc.);
- Live music/concert—hire a band to play on the parking lot of the Main Office, get food trucks there, have employees bring chairs and drinks; rent out a local amphitheater and have Michael Bowman’s (employee) band play for everyone;
- High school—partner with local high schools to create a mentorship program;
- Travel—award “Employee of the Year” and the prize will be a trip/travel voucher; create a travel program between different CPE branches where employees can switch with each other for the week and are able to see how other branches operate;
- Outdoors—have the travel prize from the “Employee of the Year” trip (see above) be at Lake Crescent in Washington State;

Full notes on Questioning Reverse Assumptions Technique: Working at Crescent

1. We have branches → We don’t have any branches
 - a. All work is done remotely (at home) and we create a hub-and-spoke distribution system to deliver to customers
 - b. Sell the business
 - c. Invest in a fleet of jets and have pilots fly product to customers
 - d. Do all consultations with customers via FaceTime, figure out what they need from there, and use fleet of jets to deliver parts/equipment to them
2. We are spread out → We are located all in one city
 - a. Have a fleet of drivers to deliver to customers not in St. Louis, then you could deliver anywhere in the US.
3. Most employees have to be in person to do their job → All employees are remote workers
 - a. Have call center to take orders, all employees work at home, deliver parts out of a main warehouse in the middle of all territories.
4. The HVAC-R industry is a male-dominated industry → It’s a female-dominated industry.
 - a. What if we only recruited and hired female workers. I used this as my prohibitive constraint – see full brainstorm in those notes below.
5. CPE is a family-owned business → We are not a family-owned business.
 - a. Become an ESOP, gives employees ownership and more buy in
 - b. We sell the business to PE or another distributor

6. We have employees → We don't have any employees.
 - a. Employ robots to do all the work, drop parts to customers with drones.
7. We have an open office plan → We have a closed office plan.
 - a. Build internal offices for all employees.
 - b. Have all employees work from home and give them stipend to purchase office supplies
8. Employees like working at CPE → Employees don't like working there
 - a. Take away all benefits
 - b. Don't give anyone time off
 - c. No paid holidays or overtime
 - d. Charge people to work for you
9. It's hard to visit branches outside of Metro STL → It's easy to visit branches outside of Metro STL.
 - a. Invest in a company helicopter or jet to fly you from branch to branch
 - b. Hire a driver to drive corporate employees from branch to branch so they can work in the car while the driver drives you there
 - c. Bring all branches to Metro STL
10. We sell HVAC-R parts and equipment → We don't sell HVAC-R parts and equipment.
 - a. We could sell other things – what could we sell that would still utilize our current expertise's
 - i. Plumbing
 - ii. Electric supplies

Full notes on Questioning Prohibitive Constraint Technique: What if we could only hire/employ female employees?

- Need to make it a more “women friendly” environment
 - Provide paid maternity leave
 - provide a paid parental leave for all employees
 - Have a mother's room for nursing mothers (currently we only use the bathroom or a conference room and put a piece of paper in the window)
 - Allow employees to bring their children to work (before/after school or while they are younger than school age)
 - Have a daycare at the main office
 - Pay for daycare expenses
 - Provide fertility benefits
 - Provide postpartum benefits (more than what is already there) – partner with an organization that helps mother's postpartum
 - Provide classes for parents – both new and not new (i.e. a class on how to deal with a teenager in the house; a class for new parents, a class for parents with toddlers, etc.)
 - Provide child first aid and CPR classes
 - Provide better PTO – new employees need more than just two weeks
 - Can we give employees an “emergency” paid time off fund that can be used when their kid is sick, they have car troubles, they need to take their partner to the doctor – so they don't have to use their PTO (which is viewed at Crescent as vacation time)

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- We currently provide employees with a Wellness Day to go to their primary care doctor for their annual physical – we should provide an extra day for women to also go to their OB for their annual exam

Full Notes on Networking:

My first call was to Mimi LeClair – Mimi retired last summer, however, before that she was the President and CEO of Boys & Girls Clubs of Chicago. Mimi and I met when we were both working at Mercy Home for Boys & Girls – she was the Vice President of Advancement and my direct supervisor. After about 20 minutes of catching up on life, I posed my question to Mimi and also asked her her strategy for retaining employees at the Boys & Girls Clubs. Mimi and I talked a lot about parental leave benefits and more PTO for employees – all things I had already idealized in the general sense, but she gave me some well-detailed policies and procedures that she already had in place.

My next call was to Peggy Sullivan, Associate Vice President of HR at Mercy Home for Boys & Girls – when I posed my question to her she seemed reluctant to give me any information. After some probing, she did give me some very vague answers about needing good benefits like health insurance and paid time off. I got the sense that she felt uncomfortable giving me any information about employee retention, it was almost like we were competitors in that space. However, she works at a non-profit in Chicago, Illinois, and I am asking about recruiting for an HVAC company in St. Louis, Missouri – which is 300 miles away. I was confused by her standoff-ness at the question, so I didn't push further.

My last call proved to be extremely helpful. It was to Shelly Liley at American Metals (she's the head of HR there) – Shelly and I met through Tugboat, a group in St. Louis that promotes private companies staying private. When I posed my question to Shelly, she got very excited and said she had just attended an Enterprise University class on exactly what I was asking – and sent me the link to watch the recorded version of the course! The ideas generated from that course were mainly for new hires, and they included: a welcome call from the manager (or next level up manager) after they accept the offer; schedule welcome coffee/lunch with manager and one other employee that they'll work with before start date; send a welcome text 48 hours before they start telling them how excited you are; give more company swag on the day they start; have manager meet the new hire at the door every day their first week; and start and end every day the first week with the new hire's manager.

Full Notes on Experimenting:

- Hardship Fund – I spoke of this idea in my networking call with Shelly Liley (I spoke to her after I had hosted the Teaming meeting) and American Metals already had a Hardship Fund through United Way. I set up a meeting with them to get all the information I needed to pitch my idea to our leadership team (see Pitching below).
- Challenge Coins – this was an idea one of my colleagues came up with during our Teaming meeting. We (literately) prototyped the coin using the company's 3-D printer and talked with other employees about the program and how we thought people could earn the coins. It seemed that many were excited to expand upon the idea, and thought of creating a plaque at the Main Office where every person that won a coin would have their name engraved.

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- I purchased antifatigue mats for two of our branches and asked employees to pay attention to their bodies and see if they felt any better after standing for longer periods of time. The first branch got back to me and said they felt the mats helped a great deal! I'm still waiting on results from the second branch.
- I surveyed all employees on our PTO policy through our Survey Monkey site – I asked if they thought they had enough PTO, if not, how much more they wanted, and asked for ideas on how we could give them more PTO but still be able to cover all of our shifts. The ideas came back very mixed, and I was surprised to see that about 1/3 of employees that responded to the survey thought our PTO policy was sufficient. The other 2/3s asked for more PTO (in varying amounts) and some even asked for unlimited PTO. Very few answered the question on how to cover all of our shifts, but one person did write in that the extra PTO could only be taken during our non-busy season (our busy season is April – September).

Pitching: Challenge Coins



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